

Best Laid PLANS

The ASI gets a tough new Act on the eve of its 150th year but it's too much, too early

By Kaverie Bamzai

The Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's personal attention. An expert review committee with Union Minister of Law and Justice M. Veerappa Moily, Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH) Chairman S.K. Misra and premier historian Nayanjot Lahiri. Seven consultations with other experts. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) should finally have got an Act worthy of the 150-year-old history it will be celebrating next year. Instead, it has crafted a law that has widened the chasm between planners and conservationists, anyway unbridgeable after the Delhi High Court held invalid several public works under the Commonwealth Games and Metro Rail which were allowed to be constructed in the prohibited areas of protected monuments. The new Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (Amendment and Validation) Act, 2010, requires such stringent policing that no change on any property within the 100-m prohibited area and the additional 200-m regulated area around a monument can be made without permission from a proposed National Monuments Authority (NMA).

Great in theory, except that the ASI is the first to admit that its control over the 3,675 protected monuments in India is tenuous. Thirty-five of its protected monuments have disappeared while 249 of them, including the Jaisalmer Fort, the Golconda Fort and the Jogeshwari Caves, are encroached upon or occupied by unauthorised per-

ILLEGAL ENCROACHMENTS IN THE GOLCONDA FORT ARE YET TO BE REMOVED



A. K. SINGH

2,500 of **3,675** centrally protected monuments do not have a single regular or full-time guard

The ASI has only **200** conservation assistants, with each holding charge of more than **18** monuments

249 protected monuments are currently encroached upon or physically occupied by unauthorised people

Rs 1,276 cr is the proportion of the Union budget spent on the Ministry of Culture. Only one-third of this is spent on the ASI.

10,000 additional posts of monument attendants and additional posts for enforcement squads will cost up to **Rs 400 cr** a year